

By Rohit Parihar

What would royalty be without palace intrigues and family feuds? More so when the members involved are fighting over the legacy of the woman who defined the romanticism, fabulous wealth and style of India's erstwhile royal houses. Gayatri Devi, once a prominent member of the global jet set and described as the most beautiful woman in the world, died three weeks ago but the controversy and mystery surrounding her legal heirs means that her soul is still to find peace.

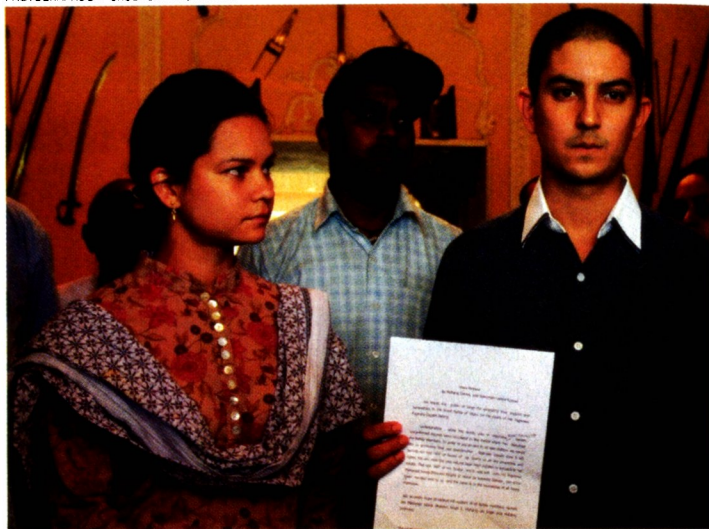
With her only child, Jagat Singh, long dead, the other claimants to her and her son's property worth an estimated Rs 2,000 crore are still embroiled in a bitter battle over the prime property and other assets, including the fabulous jewellery and paintings she left behind. Further intrigue was added recently with her Bangkok-based grandchildren claiming that they were her sole heirs and clutching what they claimed was her last will, which they never displayed. However, the fact that no one has been able to examine it closely and it is still unregistered with no mention of her personal belongings means that the claims and counter-claims within the remaining family are bound to get even more heated.

In Jaipur, there is a sense of shock at the manner in which their former rulers are conducting themselves. The big question now is where are Gayatri Devi's personal belongings? There is one more question over the validity of the last will signed a few months before her death and handed over to her eldest stepson Bhawani Singh, her late son Jagat's rival in other pending legal cases. Also, questions are being asked about what exactly she bequeathed to her other two stepsons, Jai Singh and Prithvi Raj Singh who with their families, had been taking care of her all this while.

The mystery over her properties and personal assets and the legal rights to them has added importance

LALITYA AND DEVRAJ SINGH, GRANDCHILDREN OF GAYATRI DEVI, DISPLAY A MEDIA BRIEF STAKING CLAIM TO THE POSSESSION OF A WILL

PHOTOGRAPHS BY PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



A Right Royal BATTLE

The mystery over the late Gayatri Devi's legal heirs deepens with the appearance of a dubious will. The fight for her Rs 2,000 crore legacy is not over and could get messy.

because there is reasonable public interest involved: part of it has been under state acquisition and almost all her belongings, moveable or immovable, have great heritage value attached to them with laws governing their usage and disposal. Amidst all this, there is a twist given to the case by her grandchildren Devraj Singh and Lalitya Devi, born to a Thai princess who separated from their late father Jagat. They claim that her last will was signed in Bhawani's presence and they are the sole legal heirs. This is a royal coup of sorts as



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their father Jagat had initiated court cases against Bhawani. His two step brothers Jai and Prithvi Raj also backed him. Bhawani is the other mystery. Despite his differences with Jagat, he was the one who brought